Manual Dropout in Neural Networks: A Reduced-Scale Reproduction and Ablation Study

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Abstract—Deep artificial neural networks are prone to overfitting when trained with extensive parameter capacity on finite training samples. Dropout regularizes deep networks by stochastically omitting hidden units during training to suppress co-adaptations. In this study, we present a complete from-scratch manual implementation of inverted dropout in PyTorch without built-in library abstractions. We conduct a rigorous, fixed-budget rate ablation across eight drop rates ($d \in \{0.0, 0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$) over three random seeds $(42, 43, 44)$ on a fully connected architecture ($784 \to 256 \to 256 \to 256 \to 10$). On the primary MNIST benchmark, validation error selects $d = 0.4$, reducing mean test error from $4.320 \pm 0.295\%$ to $3.843 \pm 0.282\%$ (11.03% relative reduction). On the Fashion-MNIST extension, validation selects $d = 0.2$, reducing mean test error from $14.663 \pm 0.175\%$ to $14.347 \pm 0.253\%$ (2.16% relative reduction). However, excessive drop rates degrade performance below the baseline. Under this reduced-scale educational setting, dropout provides meaningful regularization, but its optimal rate is dataset-sensitive and requires validation-based selection.

Index Terms—Dropout, regularization, neural networks, ablation study, model selection, MNIST, Fashion-MNIST.

I. Introduction

Deep neural networks possess remarkable expressive capacity, enabling them to approximate complex nonlinear functions. However, when parameter capacity is large relative to the volume of training examples, networks readily memorize training noise and overfit, yielding high generalization error on unseen test data [1].

To mitigate overfitting, ensemble methods combine predictions from multiple independently trained models. While effective, training and maintaining large ensembles of deep neural networks is computationally prohibitive. In their seminal work, Srivastava et al. [1] introduced dropout as a computationally efficient approximation to model ensembling. By stochastically dropping units during each training iteration, dropout trains an exponential family of thinned subnetworks that share weights, creating an implicit geometric ensemble at evaluation time.

The objective of this assignment is to implement dropout from first principles using Python and PyTorch without relying on built-in primitives such as torch.nn.Dropout or torch.nn.functional.dropout. We evaluate this manual implementation through a controlled drop-rate ablation across eight uniform rates ($d \in \{0.0, 0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7\}$) using three fixed initialization seeds $(42, 43, 44)$. We investigate both the primary MNIST handwritten digit benchmark [2] and an identical-protocol extension to Fashion-MNIST [3].

We emphasize that this project is an educational, reduced-scale reproduction rather than an attempt to replicate the exact state-of-the-art numerical accuracies of the original 2014 publication. We employ a fixed parameter width, a sub-sampled training set of 10,000 examples, and a constrained budget of 20 training epochs. Crucially, we adhere to strict scientific evaluation: hyperparameters and drop rates are chosen exclusively on validation data, leaving the official test set for unbiased descriptive evaluation. Our empirical findings demonstrate that while dropout yields noticeable error reductions at moderate rates, high dropout rates degrade generalization under fixed compute budgets, confirming that regularization strength must be calibrated carefully.

II. Dropout Formulation and Architecture

A. Mathematical Formulation

Let $h \in \mathbb{R}^D$ denote the post-activation vector of a hidden neural network layer. We define the drop probability as $d \in [0, 1)$ and the corresponding retention or keep probability as:

$$q = 1 - d, \quad q \in (0, 1]. \tag{1}$$

During training, a random binary mask vector $m \in \{0, 1\}^D$ is sampled independently across units from a Bernoulli distribution parameterized by q:

$$m_i \sim \text{Bernoulli}(q), \quad \mathbb{P}(m_i = 1) = q, \quad \mathbb{P}(m_i = 0) = d. \tag{2}$$

In modern deep learning implementations, inverted dropout is the standard formulation. Rather than scaling activations at test time, inverted dropout rescales the unmasked activations during training by the reciprocal of the keep probability, $1/q$:

$$\tilde{h}_i^{(\text{train})} = \frac{m_i \cdot h_i}{q}. \tag{3}$$

During evaluation (inference), the dropout operator is entirely bypassed:

$$\tilde{h}_i^{(\text{eval})} = h_i. \tag{4}$$

B. Expectation Derivation

The primary mathematical justification for the $1/q$ scaling factor is preservation of the expected activation magnitude across training and evaluation phases. For any arbitrary unit activation h_i, the conditional expectation of $\tilde{h}_i^{(\text{train})}$ given h_i is derived as follows:

$$\mathbb{E}\left[\tilde{h}_i^{(\text{train})} \mid h_i\right] = \mathbb{E}\left[\frac{m_i \cdot h_i}{q} \,\middle|\, h_i\right] \tag{5}$$

$$= \frac{h_i}{q}\,\mathbb{E}\left[m_i\right] \tag{6}$$

$$= \frac{h_i}{q} \cdot (1 \cdot \mathbb{P}(m_i = 1) + 0 \cdot \mathbb{P}(m_i = 0)) \tag{7}$$

$$= \frac{h_i}{q} \cdot q \tag{8}$$

$$= h_i. \tag{9}$$

Because $\mathbb{E}\left[\tilde{h}_i^{(\text{train})} \mid h_i\right] = \tilde{h}_i^{(\text{eval})} = h_i$, the input distribution received by subsequent downstream layers maintains an identical expected mean during training and evaluation. Consequently, downstream weights do not require post-hoc rescaling at inference time, ensuring that evaluation mode remains entirely deterministic and computationally identical to an unregularized forward pass.

C. Inverted Dropout vs. Original Paper Formulation

In the original presentation by Srivastava et al. [1], dropout was formulated using standard test-time scaling: during training, activations were unscaled ($\tilde{h}_i = m_i \cdot h_i$), and at test time, outgoing weights or activations were multiplied by the keep probability ($\tilde{h}_i = q \cdot h_i$). Reference materials on the author's project page [4] and the historical Deepnet repository [5] document this classical convention.

Both conventions are mathematically equivalent in expectation, as both maintain identical forward signal magnitudes across phases. Inverted dropout is widely preferred in modern production frameworks (such as PyTorch [6]) because it restricts stochasticity and scaling logic entirely to the training graph. At inference time, no extra arithmetic operations or memory allocations are introduced.

D. Network Architecture

All experiments employ a Multilayer Perceptron (MLP) consisting of three fully connected hidden layers:

$$\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^{784} \xrightarrow{W_1,b_1} \mathbb{R}^{256} \xrightarrow{W_2,b_2} \mathbb{R}^{256} \xrightarrow{W_3,b_3} \mathbb{R}^{256} \xrightarrow{W_4,b_4} \mathbf{y} \in \mathbb{R}^{10}. \tag{10}$$

Each linear hidden layer is followed by a Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU) activation function:

$$\sigma(z) = \max(0, z). \tag{11}$$

Our custom ManualDropout layer is inserted immediately after each hidden ReLU activation. In strict accordance with the project specification:

- No dropout is applied to the raw input layer ($d_{\text{in}} = 0$).
- No dropout is applied to the final classification logits.
- Built-in dropout routines (torch.nn.Dropout) are strictly forbidden.
- The total trainable parameter count is exactly:

$$(784 \times 256 + 256) + 2 \times (256 \times 256 + 256) + (256 \times 10 + 10) = 335{,}114. \tag{12}$$

III. Experimental Setup

A. Protocol Specification (dropout-24cs2032-v1)

We freeze the experimental configuration under protocol identifier dropout-24cs2032-v1. Key experimental parameters are detailed in Table I.

TABLE I
Frozen Experimental Protocol Parameters

Parameter	Specification
Architecture	$784 \to 256 \to 256 \to 256 \to 10$ MLP
Hidden Activation	Rectified Linear Unit (ReLU)
Dropout Placement	After hidden ReLUs (Layers 1, 2, 3)
Drop Rates (d)	$0.0, 0.1, 0.2, 0.3, 0.4, 0.5, 0.6, 0.7$
Keep Rates (q)	$1.0, 0.9, 0.8, 0.7, 0.6, 0.5, 0.4, 0.3$
Initialization Seeds	$42, 43, 44$ (3 seeds)
Split Seed	2026
Training Set Size	10,000 examples (disjoint subset)
Validation Set Size	5,000 examples (disjoint subset)
Test Set Size	10,000 examples (official test split)
Training Epochs	20 fixed epochs
Mini-Batch Size	128
Optimizer	Adam ($\beta_1 = 0.9, \beta_2 = 0.999$, $\epsilon = 10^{-8}$)
Learning Rate	0.001 (fixed, no decay schedule)
Weight Decay	0.0 (no L_2 regularization)
Other Regularizers	None (no batch norm, no max-norm)
Data Preprocessing	Division by 255.0 (float32 scaling)
Compute Backend	CPU (Apple Silicon arm64, native)

B. Data Partitioning and Fair Initialization

The official torchvision datasets [7], [8] provide 60,000 training and 10,000 test images. To operate within a standardized educational compute budget, we fix split seed 2026 to partition the 60,000 training images into 10,000 training examples, 5,000 validation examples, and 45,000 unused images. The official 10,000 test images remain completely untouched and are reserved exclusively for final evaluation.

To ensure strict experimental fairness across drop rates, we enforce deterministic initialization: for any given random seed ($s \in \{42, 43, 44\}$), the model weights across all eight drop rates ($d \in [0.0, 0.7]$) are verified to be bitwise identical at step 0 before optimization begins.

C. Model Selection and Evaluation Policy

Model selection is governed strictly by minimum validation error:

$$d^* = \arg\min_d \ \overline{\text{Error}}_{\text{val}}(d), \tag{13}$$

where $\overline{\text{Error}}_{\text{val}}(d)$ is the mean classification error across the three seeds at epoch 20. Ties are resolved by selecting the lower drop rate.

In strict adherence to sound scientific methodology, test set performance is never consulted during rate selection, checkpoint picking, or hyperparameter adjustment. All reported test errors are unbiased descriptive metrics evaluated at the fixed termination epoch ($E = 20$). Statistical dispersion is reported using the sample standard deviation ($ddof = 1$).

D. Hardware and Execution Environment

Experiments were executed on macOS 26.6.2 (Darwin arm64) using Python 3.13.9, PyTorch 2.14.1, torchvision 0.29.1, and NumPy 2.5.3. Preliminary benchmarks revealed that CPU execution required 0.785 seconds per 2-epoch run compared to 4.398 seconds on Apple Metal Performance Shaders (MPS), representing an efficiency advantage of over 5.5× for CPU. This performance difference is attributed to GPU kernel launch and synchronization latency on small parameter tensors (335k parameters). Consequently, CPU was locked as the deterministic compute backend.

IV. Experimental Results

A. MNIST Main Reproduction

The complete sweep of 24 independent runs (8 rates × 3 seeds) was executed to fixed epoch 20. Table II details the training, validation, and test error rates across all evaluated drop rates.

TABLE II
MNIST Results at Epoch 20 (Mean ± SD over Seeds 42, 43, 44)

Rate (d)	Train Error (%)	Val Error (%)	Test Error (%)
0.0 (Baseline)	0.203 ± 0.200	4.260 ± 0.533	4.320 ± 0.295
0.1	0.090 ± 0.044	4.180 ± 0.314	4.050 ± 0.278
0.2	0.110 ± 0.000	3.893 ± 0.099	3.900 ± 0.239
0.3	0.240 ± 0.080	3.753 ± 0.061	3.820 ± 0.118
0.4 (Selected)	$\mathbf{0.323 \pm 0.047}$	$\mathbf{3.747 \pm 0.130}$	$\mathbf{3.843 \pm 0.282}$
0.5 (Reference)	0.700 ± 0.044	3.840 ± 0.140	3.883 ± 0.087
0.6	1.273 ± 0.057	4.407 ± 0.219	4.380 ± 0.104
0.7	2.513 ± 0.153	5.133 ± 0.090	5.110 ± 0.147

Baseline Performance: The unregularized baseline ($d = 0.0$) achieves a training error of $0.203 \pm 0.200\%$ but a test error of $4.320 \pm 0.295\%$, representing a substantial generalization gap of 4.117 ± 0.101 percentage points (pp).

Validation-Selected Model: The lowest mean validation error is attained at drop rate $d = 0.4$ ($3.747 \pm 0.130\%$). At this rate, the model achieves a test error of $3.843 \pm 0.282\%$ (accuracy: 96.157%). Compared to the unregularized baseline, $d = 0.4$ yields an absolute reduction in test error of 0.477 pp, corresponding to a relative test error reduction of:

$$\frac{4.320 - 3.843}{4.320} \times 100\% = 11.03\%. \tag{14}$$

Furthermore, the generalization gap narrows from 4.117 pp to 3.520 ± 0.295 pp.

Test Set Nuance: Descriptively, the lowest numerical test error was observed at $d = 0.3$ ($3.820 \pm 0.118\%$). However, because model selection is strictly confined to validation data, $d = 0.4$ remains the sole authorized selected model. The difference between test error at $d = 0.3$ (3.820%) and $d = 0.4$ (3.843%) is minor (0.023 pp) and falls well within the sample standard deviation (0.282%).

Negative Findings: When the drop rate is increased to $d = 0.6$ and $d = 0.7$, test performance deteriorates to $4.380 \pm 0.104\%$ and $5.110 \pm 0.147\%$ respectively, both performing markedly worse than the unregularized baseline.

B. Fashion-MNIST Extension

To evaluate whether these regularizing properties generalize beyond digit recognition, we executed the identical 24-run protocol on Fashion-MNIST [3]. Table III summarizes the results.

TABLE III
Fashion-MNIST Results at Epoch 20 (Mean ± SD over Seeds 42, 43, 44)

Rate (d)	Train Error (%)	Val Error (%)	Test Error (%)
0.0 (Baseline)	7.130 ± 0.177	13.127 ± 0.247	14.663 ± 0.175
0.1	7.587 ± 0.471	13.113 ± 0.042	14.220 ± 0.105
0.2 (Selected)	$\mathbf{8.583 \pm 0.414}$	$\mathbf{13.087 \pm 0.408}$	$\mathbf{14.347 \pm 0.253}$
0.3	9.393 ± 0.067	13.267 ± 0.244	14.567 ± 0.396
0.4	10.060 ± 0.584	13.573 ± 0.494	14.647 ± 0.330
0.5 (Reference)	10.990 ± 0.366	13.747 ± 0.200	15.133 ± 0.325
0.6	12.273 ± 0.323	14.380 ± 0.053	15.730 ± 0.373
0.7	14.543 ± 0.468	15.673 ± 0.380	17.453 ± 0.376

Baseline Performance: The unregularized baseline ($d = 0.0$) produces a test error of $14.663 \pm 0.175\%$ with a generalization gap of 7.533 ± 0.351 pp.

Validation-Selected Model: Validation error selects drop rate $d = 0.2$ ($13.087 \pm 0.408\%$). The selected model attains a test error of $14.347 \pm 0.253\%$ (accuracy: 85.653%), yielding an absolute reduction of 0.317 pp (2.16% relative reduction) and contracting the generalization gap to 5.763 ± 0.165 pp.

Critical Negative Finding: Notably, the standard paper reference rate of $d = 0.5$ yields a test error of $15.133 \pm 0.325\%$, which is 0.470 pp worse than the no-dropout baseline. At $d = 0.7$, test error degrades sharply to $17.453 \pm 0.376\%$. This highlights that applying a canonical drop rate of $d = 0.5$ without validation tuning can actively harm model accuracy on more complex visual benchmarks.

C. Learning Dynamics and Overfitting

Figure 1 illustrates the epoch-wise training error, test error, and validation loss trajectories on MNIST for the baseline ($d = 0.0$) and reference dropout ($d = 0.5$).

In the baseline model ($d = 0.0$), training error rapidly declines toward 0.2%, while validation loss diverges after epoch 6, evidencing severe memorization. In contrast, with

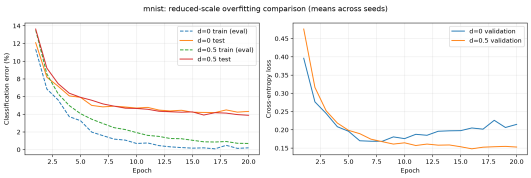


Fig. 1. Epoch-wise learning dynamics on MNIST comparing unregularized training ($d = 0.0$) against dropout ($d = 0.5$) under our reduced-scale protocol (10,000 training examples, 20 epochs). While the unregularized model drives training error toward zero and exhibits rising validation loss (overfitting), dropout regularizes the representation, maintaining stable validation loss and lower test error.

dropout enabled ($d = 0.5$), training error declines more gradually, and validation loss stabilizes at a lower plateau, illustrating effective regularization of network capacity.

D. Keep-Probability Ablation Curves

Figure 2 and Figure 3 present the relationships between test error and keep probability $q = 1 - d$ for MNIST and Fashion-MNIST respectively.

The MNIST curve (Fig. 2) displays a distinct U-shaped profile. When $q = 1.0$ (no dropout), overfitting leads to elevated test error (4.320%). As q decreases into the intermediate regime ($q \in [0.6, 0.9]$, corresponding to $d \in [0.1, 0.4]$), test error reaches an optimal trough between 3.820% and 3.900%. However, when retention falls to $q \leq 0.4$ ($d \geq 0.6$), test error rises steeply to 5.110%.

On Fashion-MNIST (Fig. 3), the optimal retention is higher ($q = 0.8$, $d = 0.2$). As retention probability decreases below $q = 0.5$ ($d > 0.5$), performance degrades rapidly.

V. Discussion and Comparison with Srivastava et al. (2014)

A. Comparison with Original Findings

In Table 2 of Srivastava et al. [1], the authors report a test error of 1.25% for a standard feedforward neural network with dropout and ReLU activations on MNIST. In our reduced-scale reproduction, our baseline achieves $4.320 \pm 0.295\%$ and our validation-selected model achieves $3.843 \pm 0.282\%$.

We explicitly state that these numerical scores are not directly comparable due to major methodological and budget differences:

1) Network Capacity: Srivastava et al. employed wide networks with 2,048 to 8,192 units per hidden layer (10× to 30× more parameters), whereas our model utilizes 256 units per layer (335,114 parameters).
2) Dataset Scale: The original paper utilized all 60,000 available training examples, compared to our subsampled set of 10,000 training examples.
3) Training Budget and Optimization: The original work trained networks for hundreds of epochs using Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD) with momentum, coupled with max-norm weight clipping ($\|W\|_2 \leq c$). Our experiment employs the Adam optimizer for 20 epochs with no weight constraints.
4) Regularization Formulation: We utilize modern inverted dropout rather than test-time weight rescaling.

Despite these substantial numerical differences, our experiments successfully reproduce the fundamental qualitative finding of Srivastava et al. (Fig. 9(a)): the generalization error exhibits a U-shaped dependence on retention probability, where intermediate values offer optimal regularization, and extreme dropout rates underfit the training data.

B. Differential Regularization Behavior

A compelling finding of this study is the marked difference in optimal drop rate between MNIST ($d^* = 0.4$) and Fashion-MNIST ($d^* = 0.2$). MNIST digits consist of clean, high-contrast, stroke-based patterns with substantial redundant pixel information, making the representations highly amenable to aggressive unit deactivation.

Conversely, Fashion-MNIST exhibits complex, subtle textures and fine-grained visual distinctions between apparel categories. Under a constrained budget of 20 epochs, excessive dropout suppresses critical feature channels, impairing representational capacity and resulting in severe underfitting for $d \geq 0.5$.

VI. Failure Analysis and Limitations

A. Empirical Failure Case Analysis

To understand the nature of model errors, we inspected misclassified test examples from the validation-selected models across both datasets. Figure 4 displays representative test failure cases.

On MNIST (Fig. 4, left), typical errors involve ambiguous handwriting: a handwritten digit with true label 2 is classified as 3 with confidence 0.52, and a handwritten digit with true label 9 is classified as 8 with confidence 0.91. From visual inspection, the handwritten strokes in these instances exhibit morphological features that resemble the predicted alternative classes. We emphasize this is an empirical visual observation of stroke similarity rather than a proven causal claim regarding latent activations.

On Fashion-MNIST (Fig. 4, right), errors consistently concentrate at boundaries between semantically adjacent clothing categories: a true Coat is classified as Pullover with confidence 0.71, and a true Ankle Boot is classified as Sneaker with confidence 0.99. At 28×28 grayscale resolution, global silhouettes of coats and pullovers or boots and sneakers appear visually similar. Fully connected networks lack spatial inductive bias, rendering subtle texture distinctions challenging to resolve under low resolution and small training budgets.

B. Methodological Limitations

We identify the following methodological constraints:

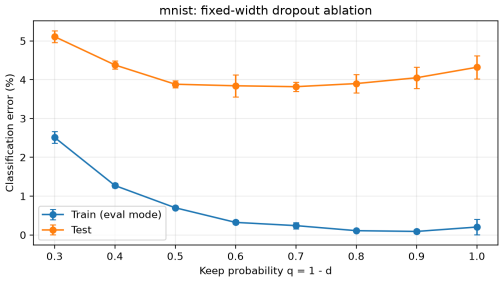


Fig. 2. Reduced-scale fixed-width dropout rate ablation on MNIST inspired by Srivastava et al. [1], Fig. 9(a). Data points depict measured experimental results (mean ± sample SD across three seeds) plotted against keep probability $q = 1 - d$.

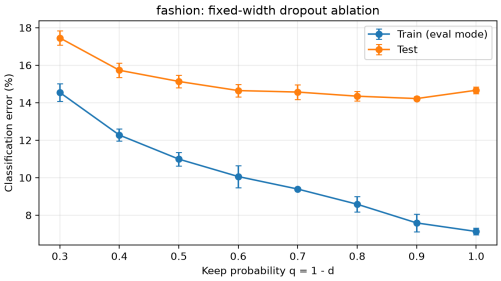


Fig. 3. Keep-probability ablation curve for Fashion-MNIST extension under protocol dropout-24cs2032-v1. Error increases monotonically for retention probabilities below $q = 0.8$ ($d > 0.2$).

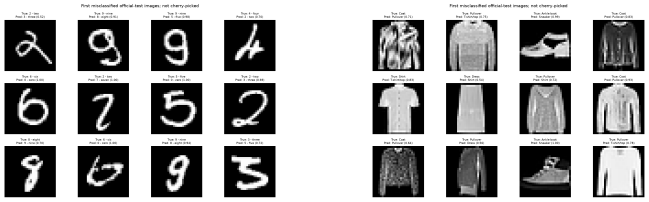


Fig. 4. Representative misclassified test instances on MNIST ($d = 0.4$, left) and Fashion-MNIST ($d = 0.2$, right) showing true labels, model predictions, and softmax confidences.

1) Seed Sample Size: All results are evaluated over three random seeds $(42, 43, 44)$. While reporting sample standard deviation with $ddof = 1$ reflects variance, this sample size is insufficient for formal statistical significance testing.
2) Fixed Training Budget: All models were trained for exactly 20 epochs. High dropout rates inherently slow down convergence; allocating additional epochs might partially recover performance for $d \geq 0.5$.
3) Subsampled Training Split: Using 10,000 training examples magnifies regularizer sensitivity relative to the full 60,000 dataset.
4) Verification Scope: The results reported here were executed and verified locally on Apple Silicon CPU hardware. Hosted cloud execution (Google Colab) has not been verified.

VII. Conclusion

This study presented a complete, from-scratch implementation of inverted dropout in PyTorch, accompanied by an empirical ablation study across eight drop rates on MNIST and Fashion-MNIST. By strictly adhering to validation-based model selection, we demonstrated that moderate dropout rates reliably reduce test error relative to the unregularized baseline (11.03% relative reduction on MNIST at $d = 0.4$; 2.16% relative reduction on Fashion-MNIST at $d = 0.2$).

Crucially, our experiments also revealed negative results: canonical rates such as $d = 0.5$ underperformed the baseline on Fashion-MNIST, and high drop rates ($d \geq 0.6$) degraded accuracy across both benchmarks. These findings corroborate the core regularization hypothesis of Srivastava et al. while confirming that dropout is not universally beneficial without systematic validation calibration.

Assistance and Provenance Statement

Artificial intelligence tools (ChatGPT and Antigravity) were employed for implementation guidance, code review, local workflow automation, verification, and documentation formatting. All experimental results, figures, tables, and numerical metrics presented in this paper originate entirely from recorded real-data runs executed in this project repository and independently audited from persistent artifacts. External assistance is disclosed in accordance with course policy.

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